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Reading Synthesis Three: David Harvey and Tomomi Yamaguchi

The relationship between neoliberalism and fascism can perhaps be described as unquestionable within certain circles but not apparent enough to sound the alarm to the rest of the world. What I mean by this is that if one were to look at current events in tandem with political trends, there would surely be some objective observations: the rise of right wing coalitions not only across Western democracies, but their Eastern counterparts as well. Yet simultaneously, some may question the appropriateness of using fascism to characterize a time of relative stability. Even progressive thinkers might caution the overuse of fascist accusations for the avoidance of reducing a dangerous, annihilating ideology into meaningless culture war games. But in order to properly combat fascism, one must understand it, and in order to fully understand it, one must keep an open and vigilant mind that doesn't dismiss the subversive, more banal ways fascism takes root. Regarding neoliberalism, David Harvey presents a solid case for the philosophy's history, strategy, and effects, scouring the entire globe for trends that mark a kind of turning point toward the alienated, commodified, vulnerability where fascism festers. Here, I will compare some of his investigation points to the work of Tomomi Yamaguchi, whose work by contrast focuses on a specific instance of the encroaching right wing in Japanese society. By the end, I hope to shed some light on the ways that fascism might still be operating in this day and age.

A significant portion of Harvey's section on "Neoliberalism and the Restoration of Class Power" looks to the seemingly unique situation in China after the death of Mao in 1976. On the one hand, the peculiarity lies in the nation's status as an economic miracle (Harvey, 35), which arises from the extraordinary growth the country experienced only after the conditions set by earlier neoliberal policy had opened a spot for the soon-to-be economic giant. On the other, Harvey argues that this opening-up effect can also be regarded as an echo to what Japan and the East Asian "tigers" experienced up until the 1980's (Harvey, 30). Furthermore, this comparison holds more sway when one considers the popping of Japan's bubble economy and the subsequent fall of real estate, a pattern that is appearing more and more discernable in China. But if we take this developmental parallel with other forms of neoliberal and eventually neoconservative correction, it will seem that the material logics underlying these various regimes aren't all that different despite seemingly ideological or governmental differences. Indeed, Harvey's evidence corroborates this with the recent rise in nationalist sentiments in China and Japan as well as the three-sided symmetry both these nations share with Singapore, a city state marked by an air of moral superiority, neoliberal market activity, and a draconian state power (Harvey, 61). In Japan, one can see the way in which this authoritarian side shows its face by examining how the government treats the history of comfort women, which is the subject of Yamaguchi's "The History Wars and the Comfort Woman Issue: Revisionism and the Right Wing in Contemporary Japan and the U.S.". In this article, Yamaguchi cites numerous cases where attempts to erect a Statue of Peace (Yamaguchi, 2) in the United States were met with acts of resistance that largely stemmed as a direct result of intervention by the Japanese state, i.e., the consulate. Notwithstanding the fact that the entire revisionist attitude of this campaign drew from pseudohistorical and pseudointellectual reasons, I wish to underscore an example where the

divide between liberal democracy and authoritarian control state becomes ever so muddled. In the city of Southfield Michigan, just outside of Detroit, every attempt to build a Statue of Peace in a public location ultimately failed because of consistent pressure by the Consulate General and the fear of souring the city's relationship with Denso, a Japanese auto parts manufacturer (Yamaguchi, 8). To return to the Harvey, if this were instead China, it would typically be to no one's surprise that the Communist Party exercised direct control over a corporation when it needed to save political face. But this was Japan, an American ally and a practitioner of democracy, a nation which outwardly shed its imperial past. This point drives home the idea which Harvey presented on the rather expected route that China took at the turn of the millennia, which is that the turn toward the right, neoconservatism, neonationalism, and all the like, was more an indicator than a break from the antidemocratic tendencies of the neoliberal genesis (Harvey, 41). And once again, despite the ideological and economic differences which these states operated on (communist, democratic, authoritarian), once you observed the material reality of what was happening, they didn't appear all that different; fascism is where the far left meets the far right, and those conditions are simply exacerbated by the austerities introduced by neoliberalism.